

DAY 2: REDUCE YOUR RENT

I'm a pretty picky person when it comes to apartments. They need to be located in a good part of town, and decently clean. Unfortunately, the small apartment Joseph and I moved to when we relocated to Florida was neither.

The price was quite reasonable compared to the other apartment complexes and condos offering oodles of services we didn't need, but I had a lot of scrubbing to do before we called it home, not to mention feeling just a tiny bit scared any time I ventured outside those four walls. Let's just say it wasn't uncommon to see the sheriff department's helicopter flying overhead!

Even though we wanted to buy a house as soon as possible, we needed this rental to help us through the transition period while we figured out exactly *what* house we wanted, and *where* we wanted to buy it.

As a renter, you might be in transition too—maybe you're saving towards a down payment, or renting because it allows you the flexibility to move in case a job takes you out of town. Or, you could be perfectly content to continue renting for as long as you need, avoiding those expensive home repairs and maintenance we homeowners have to deal with on a monthly, sometimes weekly, basis.

No matter your reasoning for pursuing the rental lifestyle, months of payments can feel just like a mortgage, minus the added benefit of equity. And what do you do when the price increases, year after year? Unless you have a great relationship with your landlord, this expense is one that has nowhere to go but up. Here's how to reverse the trend:

1. DO YOUR RESEARCH

Don't ever think rent is non-negotiable, because it always is! The worst your landlord can say is "No," so it's certainly worth a try. Take time to research the rental market for yourself, and be well-informed of the going rate in your area before you ever sign a contract. If you've been looking at a